

and Solaris—so finding a package for your system is not likely to be an issue.

User interface and layout

Once you've installed Blender, it is time to run it! Blender is meant to run in full-screen mode by default, though a windowed mode is also available.

When working with 3D models, you will need to switch from one *viewport* (also called a window) to another. By default, the Blender interface (see Figure 1) consists of:

1. The 3D viewport: The large mid-section of the interface, where you view and work with 3D objects.
2. The buttons window: The buttons in this window allow you to edit, manipulate and alter the objects visible in the 3D viewport.
3. The *User Preferences* window: Its header is shown at the very top of the Blender interface.

In Blender, almost all functions have a direct keyboard shortcut to facilitate quicker work. Plus, the various parts of the interface are all drawn in OpenGL, and thus can be handled in much the same way as 3D elements. Therefore, you can zoom in and out of GUI buttons, like you would with the contents of the 3D viewport.

Blender has two main work modes: Object Mode and Edit Mode. Object Mode is used to edit entire objects (such as a complete model of a rectangle), while Edit Mode is used to work with individual components of objects (like the

Key Combo	Action
Numpad 5	Toggles between Perspective and Orthographic views
Numpad 2, 4, 6, 8 (arrow keys)	Moves around in the workspace
Numpad +	Zooms in
Numpad -	Zooms out
Numpad 0	Centres view of the selected object

Table 1: Numeric keypad shortcuts

individual vertices of a rectangle). The *<Tab>* key is used to toggle between the two modes.

The 3D viewport

Blender's 3D viewport (the dark grey area with the grid, which takes up most of the area in Figure 1) is where all the action happens; so let's first cover this section in detail.

Movement in the 3D viewport is controlled by the mouse and the numeric keypad on the keyboard. The basic numeric keys you should bear in mind are 7, 1 and 3, for the top, front and right views, respectively. Placing the cursor anywhere in the viewport and typing these numbers takes you to the appropriate view. By default, 0 refers to the centred camera view (see Figure 2).

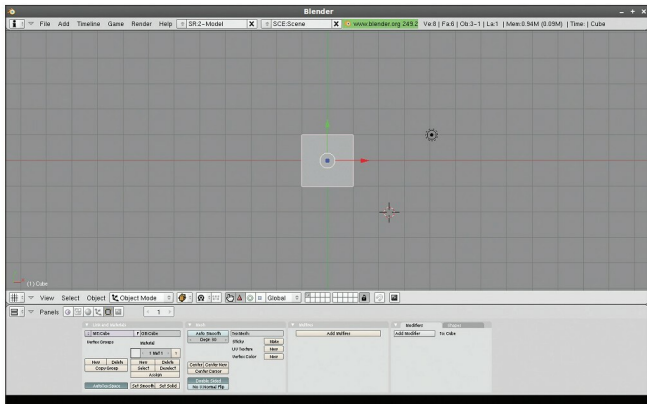


Figure 1: The Blender default interface